PRACTICE CONNECTION

Groups Facilitator Guide

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A Note to Facilitators

Thank you for helping people practice building stronger connections.

Practice Connection begins with a simple idea: how we connect can change through practice.

Many of us want more connection, but we end up unintentionally protecting ourselves from rejection, disappointment or vulnerability. We might wait for others to reach out, assume we aren't wanted, hide parts of ourselves, overgive or pull away when things feel uncertain.

Understanding these patterns is helpful, but change also requires new experiences. Practice Connection offers an opportunity to try something different, notice what happens and decide what to practice next. Over time, these experiments can change the way we see and relate to ourselves and each other.

We practice in groups because it reminds us that we are not alone in finding connection difficult. It gives us a place to reflect, learn from one another and practice being listened to without being judged or fixed.

A Practice Connection group is not therapy, and no one is expected to disclose more than they want to or succeed at every experiment. Your role as a facilitator is simply to create a thoughtful space where participants can be curious about their patterns, choose a manageable practice and learn from what happens.

Thank you for helping make connection feel more possible.

Aysha

Using Practice Connection in a Group

The Card Deck

The Card Deck contains 36 relational experiments addressing common challenges with connection. Each card invites you to try something in everyday life and asks a question to help you reflect on what you notice. The cards are organized into five categories:

ANCHOR: Practices to ground yourself before or after an experiment
SEE CLEARLY: Understand what gets in the way of connection
MOVE TOWARD: Reach out and initiate connection
SHARE YOURSELF: Practice letting yourself be seen
STAY CONNECTED: Build relationships that can grow, change, and last
BLANK CARDS: Create your own practices

There is no wrong place to start. Participants can choose the practices that feel most relevant to them and move through the deck at their own pace.

Where possible, we recommend one deck per participant. This allows each person to explore the cards privately and keep their chosen card with them between sessions. If participants are sharing decks, invite them to take a photo of the card they choose.

The Group

Practice happens predominantly in participants' own lives, between sessions. The group sessions are opportunities to come together and learn alongside others.

The same group of 6-8 people meets weekly for an hour for 6-12 weeks. In the groups, participants reflect on what they tried, what they noticed and what they learned. The group becomes a witness, a supportive space to try new things and a reminder that many of the challenges we experience in connection are shared.

Creating the Group Space

Talking about when we feel connected–and when we don't–can bring up shame, vulnerability or fear. Experimenting with new ways of relating can also feel risky. Three shared agreements help create the conditions for people to participate honestly and at their own pace. Introduce them during the first session and uphold them throughout the group.

1. **We'd love to hear your voice, but you choose whether—and how much—to share.**
2. **When someone shares, listen for what stays with you.** If you respond, you might reflect what you heard or share what resonated. Avoid offering advice, interpreting their experience or trying to solve it.
3. **Take your learning with you; leave other people's stories in the room.**

Facilitation tips:

- Consider participating alongside the group by choosing cards, trying experiments and sharing what you learn. When possible, avoid always sharing first or last.
- Don't single anyone out for not sharing; instead, ask the group if anyone else would like to share. Pause for a few seconds, and if no one else speaks up, feel free to move on.
- Encourage participants to count to seven after their peer stops sharing and before they start speaking. This gives everyone time to absorb what was just shared.
- Avoid rushing someone who is actively finding their words, while protecting time for others to contribute.
- Before inviting someone to speak again, make room for others.

If someone needs more support: Practice Connection is not therapy or crisis support. If a participant becomes distressed, pause, ask what they need and follow your organization's established support or referral procedures.

The First Session

The main purpose of the first session is to help participants build trust, decide how they want to be together as a group, and develop an understanding of connection. The session ends with each participant choosing one small experiment to try.

This first meeting is longer and more structured than subsequent sessions, so participants have a shared foundation for the practice and the conversations that follow. Below is an agenda to run your first session. Feel free to adapt for your audience.

Topic	Timing
Welcome and introductions	10 minutes
60-second portraits	10 minutes
Shared agreements	15 minutes
Group discussion	20 minutes
Envisioning connection	15 minutes
Card selection	15 minutes
Close	5 minutes
TOTAL	**90 minutes**

Timings are approximate. If conversation runs long, shorten the large-group discussion or vision-sharing portion. Protect enough time for participants to choose a card and close the session together.

Before the session, arrange seating so participants can see one another. Have decks, paper, pens, a timer, flip-chart paper and markers ready.

1. Welcome and introductions — 10 minutes

Steps:

1. Welcome participants and introduce yourself
2. Introduce the purpose of the group
    - Use small experiments to explore how we connect with others in our everyday lives, then return to reflect and learn together
3. Walk through today's agenda
4. Invite each person to share their name

2. 60-second portraits — 10 minutes

Overview: In pairs, participants draw each other for 60 seconds using one continuous line, without lifting their pens or looking down at the page. The purpose of this activity is to create an embodied experience of seeing and being seen and is adapted from *DrawTogether Strangers by Wendy MacNaughton*.

Materials: One sheet of paper and a pen per person; timer

Steps:

1. Pair participants and introduce the activity
    - Emphasize that the exercise is about seeing each other and not about drawing well.
2. Set the timer and draw for 60 seconds without looking down at the page
3. Invite participants to reveal their drawings to each other and optionally exchange three appreciative words
4. In the large group, ask: What was it like to look closely at someone and to be seen by them?
5. Connect the experience to relational experiments

3. Shared agreements — 15 minutes

Overview: As a group, decide how the group will create a supportive space to practice and share. Recommend that these agreements are recorded and are visible each session.

Materials: Flip chart paper and marker

Steps:

1. Introduce the three starting agreements from page 4.
2. Invite participants to share what stands out or needs clarification.
3. In pairs or trios, invite participants to share with each other:
    - How would you like others to show up for *you* in this group?
    - How would *you* like to show up for others in the group?
4. Invite each pair or trio to share one thing their conversation surfaced. On the flip chart, add or refine agreements based on the discussion, while preserving the core intentions of choice, non-judgment and confidentiality.

4. Group discussion — 20 minutes

Overview: As a group, explore connection and protective patterns

Steps:

1. Use a few of the questions below to open a conversation
    - What does feeling connected look and feel like to you?
    - What can make connection easier or harder?
    - What does it mean to “get better” at connection?
2. Introduce self-protective patterns. See the box below for additional information.
3. Use a few of the following questions to explore further:
    - What are some behaviours or patterns that can keep someone disconnected, even when they want connection?
    - How might a protective response make sense?
    - How can we recognize a protective pattern without criticizing ourselves for having it?
4. Summarize what you heard
    - Reinforce that connection looks different for different people and that the goal is not to eliminate self-protection, but to develop more choice in how we respond.

What are self-protective patterns?

When connection feels uncertain or risky, most of us develop habits that protect us from rejection, disappointment, embarrassment or being hurt. These patterns usually make sense. They often formed for good reasons, and they may still protect us in some situations. The difficulty is that they can also keep us from the connection we want.

Everyone has these patterns. They aren't flaws or diagnoses, and they can show up differently depending on the relationship, setting or day.

Talking about patterns

- Invite participants to recognize patterns in themselves, not to identify them in others.
- Encourage language that describes behaviour rather than identity: "I sometimes pull away" rather than "I'm avoidant."
- Acknowledge that for some people, caution reflects real experiences of being excluded, judged or harmed. Self-protection can still be wise. Participants decide when and where to experiment.
- If a participant begins to explore painful history in depth, acknowledge what they've shared and bring the focus back to the present: "Thank you for sharing that. What do you notice about how that shows up for you now?"

Common patterns

Pattern	What it can protect against	What it can cost
Waiting for others to reach out or assuming you aren't wanted	Rejection or being a bother	Others may read distance as disinterest, and connections don't get started
Hiding what you think, feel or need	Judgment, conflict or disappointing others	People connect with only part of you, and your needs go unmet
Giving or accommodating to earn belonging	Being unwanted or left out	Relationships can feel conditional or one-sided, and resentment can build
Pulling away when closeness feels uncomfortable	Being hurt, overwhelmed or dependent	Relationships don't get the chance to deepen
Replaying interactions or focusing on what went wrong	Making the same mistakes again	Attention stays on threat, making the next reach harder

5. Envisioning connection — 15 minutes

Overview: Each participant writes or draws about a day in the future when they feel more connected, whatever that means to them. The purpose of this exercise is to help them begin identifying and expressing what they are working toward.

Materials: One sheet of paper per person

Steps:

1. Introduce the exercise and encourage participants to be as detailed or dreamy as they like.
2. Give participants 7–8 minutes to write or draw.
3. Invite participants to share one part of their vision with a partner or the group.
4. Ask participants to reflect: What is one small sign you might notice over the next few weeks that would tell you you're moving in this direction?

6. Card selection — 15 minutes

Overview: Participants explore the Practice Connection deck and select a card that could help them take one small step toward the connected life they imagined.

Materials: One Practice Connection deck per person

Steps:

1. Invite participants to explore the deck and choose a relevant, manageable experiment.
    - Refer to the *How to Pick a Card* section on Page 10 if someone needs help.
2. In pairs, invite participants to share what card they chose and what trying it out might look like.

If decks are being shared, remind participants to take a photo of their chosen card.

7. Close — 5 minutes

Steps:

1. Invite participants to share one word or short phrase about what they are taking with them.
2. Remind participants that their card is an experiment, not an assignment. They may try it, adapt it, or discover that something gets in the way. All of this gives them something to learn from.
3. Close by thanking participants and sharing session structure and logistics for the following week.

How to Pick a Card

Whenever possible, invite participants to choose their own cards. Choosing what feels relevant and manageable is part of the practice: it preserves participants' agency and avoids asking the facilitator to interpret or diagnose what someone needs. A useful first card feels realistic to try and focuses on something within the participant's control.

If a participant feels unsure where to begin or overwhelmed by the number of choices, use the table below to offer a few possible starting points. Treat these as suggestions, not prescriptions, and let the participant decide what fits. If no relational experiment feels manageable yet, **SEEK ALIVENESS** offers a gentle, resourcing place to begin.

Remind the group that there is no hierarchy among the cards. A more vulnerable or challenging experiment is not better, and card selection should not become a measure of courage or progress. Each person is beginning from a different place and choosing the next step that is right for them.

If you tend to…	**Start by looking at…**
Feel unsure where to begin or feel like you don't have anyone to practice with	SEEK ALIVENESS, NOTICE WHAT IS ALREADY HERE, or SAY YES
Replay interactions or focus on what went wrong	FLIP THE SCRIPT, NOTICE WHO IS TALKING, or ABSORB THE GOOD
Wait for others or assume you aren't wanted	FLIP THE SCRIPT, KEEP THE THREAD ALIVE, or EXTEND AN INVITE
Give or accommodate to earn belonging	SEEK ALIVENESS or NOTICE THE URGE TO EARN
Hide what you think, feel or need	LET THE FEAR COME TOO, SAY THE THING, or ASK OUT LOUD
Pull away when closeness feels uncomfortable	RETURN TO YOURSELF, MEET YOURSELF HERE, or LET THEM KNOW

Subsequent Sessions

The main purpose of subsequent sessions is to give participants space to share what they tried, what they noticed and what they learned, and to be witnessed by the group as they do.

Participants do not need to have completed their experiment successfully, or at all, to contribute. What helped, what got in the way and what they felt when an opportunity arose are all useful parts of the practice.

The group is also a place to practice. How we listen, how we ask for what we need and how we respond to one another in the room are all part of learning to connect. The sharing format below is designed to make that practice feel safe.

Session at a glance

Topic	Timing
Arrive and anchor	5 minutes
Revisit agreements	2 minutes
Sharing round	45 minutes
Choose your next practice	3 minutes
Close	5 minutes
TOTAL	**60 minutes**

Timings assume a group of 8. Each turn takes about 5 to 6 minutes: 3 to 4 minutes of sharing, followed by 1 to 2 minutes of reflection when the speaker would like them. During the listening-only phase, shares can run a little longer. With a smaller group, give each person more time rather than ending early. Protect time for the close.

1. Arrive and anchor — 5 minutes

Overview: Begin with a practice from the Anchor category to help participants settle and arrive.

Steps:

1. Lead a practice from an Anchor card, or invite a participant to choose one.

2. Revisit agreements — 2 minutes

Overview: Briefly remind the group of the shared agreements, which should be visible each session.

Steps:

1. Point to the agreements and ask for a volunteer to select one or two and share what it means to them.

3. Sharing round — 45 minutes

Overview: Each participant takes a turn sharing about their experiment while the group listens. After each share, the speaker chooses whether they would like reflections or would like to just be heard.

Steps:

1. Invite someone to share.
2. The speaker shares about their experiment for about 3 to 4 minutes. They may draw on any of these questions:
    - What did you try, or intend to try?
    - What did you notice?
    - What happened that you didn't expect?
    - What helped, or what got in the way?
    - What did the experience teach you about yourself or other people?
3. [If including reflections] Ask the speaker: Would you like reflections, or would you like to just be heard?
    - If they would like to be heard, thank them and move to the next person.
    - If they would like reflections, invite up to two people to respond using the stem: "What stayed with me was…" Allow about 1 to 2 minutes for reflections in total.
4. Continue until everyone who wants to share has had the opportunity.

Facilitator note: Someone may want reflections one week and quiet the next. Asking for what we need is itself a relational practice, so treat each choice with the same warmth.

Offering reflections

A reflection names something from the speaker's share that stayed with the listener. It stays with what the speaker said rather than adding to it.

Reflections might sound like:

- What stayed with me was how much courage it took just to send that first message.
- What stayed with me was when you said you noticed yourself pulling away, and stayed anyway.

Reflections are **NOT:**

- Advice: “Next time you could try…”
- Interpretation: “It sounds like this is really about your family”
- Redirecting to your own story: “That happened to me too, and…”
- Reassurance that dismisses the feeling: “You shouldn’t feel bad about that”

If a response drifts, gently redirect: Let's come back to what stayed with you from what they shared.

Phasing in reflections

Introduce reflections gradually, so the group can first build trust and a shared rhythm of listening.

First one or two subsequent sessions: Listening only. After each share, pause for a count of seven and thank the speaker. Explain that the group is practising listening fully, and that reflections will be introduced once everyone has a feel for the round.

Once the group is ready: Introduce the speaker's choice and the "What stayed with me was…" stem. For the first few reflections, the facilitator can model by offering one themselves, so participants hear what a reflection sounds like.

Use your judgment. If the group is feeling tender, it is always fine to return to listening only for a session.

4. Choose your next practice — 3 minutes

Overview: Give participants quiet time to choose a new card or adjust their experiment.

Steps:

1. Invite participants to spend a few minutes with their deck or journal and select the practice they want to experiment with during the week.
2. Remind them that the goal is not to move through the deck quickly, but to keep experimenting and learning. If decks are being shared, remind them to take a photo of their chosen card.

5. Close — 5 minutes

Steps:

1. Invite participants to share one word or short phrase about what they are taking with them.
2. Thank participants and share details for the next session.

The Final Session

The final session helps participants look back, name what they're taking with them and mark the ending together. Endings are part of connection too, and closing well can be its own experience of practice.

Before the final session: In the previous session, let participants know the next session is the last one and invite them to bring the vision they created in the first session.

Session at a glance

Topic	Timing
Arrive and anchor	5 minutes
Look back	10 minutes
Appreciation	20 minutes
Closing reflections	20 minutes
Close	5 minutes

As in every session, participants choose whether and how much to share out loud.

1. Arrive and anchor — 5 minutes

Overview: Begin with a practice from the Anchor category to help participants settle and arrive.

Steps:

1. Lead a practice from an Anchor card, or invite a participant to choose one.
2. Allow a moment of quiet before moving into the final session.

2. Look back — 10 minutes

Overview: Participants revisit the vision they created during the first session and reflect on what has changed, what they learned and what they are proud of.

Materials: Participants' first-session visions, paper or journals, and pens

Steps:

1. Invite participants to reread the vision they created during the first session.
2. Give them time to reflect and write using the following questions:
    - What feels closer now?
    - Whether things went to plan or not, what are you proud of?
    - What surprised you or shifted for you?
3. Let participants know they will have an opportunity to share during the closing reflection.

3. Appreciation — 20 minutes

Overview: Participants name what they appreciated, noticed or will remember about each person in the group. Everyone leaves with a collection of appreciative reflections from their peers.

Materials: Sticky notes and markers; optional named sheets and tape

Steps:

1. Give each participant a stack of sticky notes and a marker.
2. Invite participants to move around the room and share one word that describes each person in the group.
3. Offer the following sentence stems if helpful:
    - Something I appreciated about you was…
    - Something I'll remember about you was…
    - Something you brought to this group was…
4. Participants may place the notes on one another's backs—with permission—or on named sheets posted around the room.
5. Once everyone has finished, invite participants to help one another collect their notes.
6. Allow a few quiet minutes for participants to read what others wrote.

4. Closing reflections — 20 minutes

Overview: Participants reflect on the relationship they developed with the group and name what they want to carry forward.

Steps:

1. Invite participants to respond to the following questions:
    - What have you given to this group? What has it given you?
    - What is something you want to keep practicing or carry forward?
2. Allow participants to share popcorn-style, without moving in a predetermined order.
3. Make space for everyone who wants to speak before inviting second contributions.

5. Close — 5 minutes

Overview: Acknowledge what the group created together and mark the ending.

Steps:

1. Thank participants for what they brought to the group and for how they showed up for one another.
2. Remind them that the relationships and learning developed through the group can continue beyond the sessions.
3. Acknowledge the ending and formally close the group.

Staying in touch

Some participants may want to stay connected after the group ends. Name this openly, and if the group would like to share contact details, make it opt-in rather than circulating a list. Remind participants that the third agreement still applies: take your learning with you, and leave other people's stories in the room.

Resources and Other Ideas

This guide offers one way to use Practice Connection with a group. Facilitators and participants are encouraged to adapt the format, invent new rituals and find what suits their community.

Practice Connection Journal: The companion journal offers space to envision the relationships participants want, plan experiments, and reflect on what they're learning. Download it at https://practiceconnectioncards.com/journal.pdf

Digital deck: A digital version of the deck is available at https://practiceconnectioncards.com, which can be useful for groups sharing decks or meeting online.

Make room for informal connection: Leave the final 15 minutes of each session—or extend the session by 15 minutes—for unstructured conversation. This gives participants an opportunity to get to know one another beyond the facilitated discussion. After the final session, consider inviting the group to stay for a potluck or continue the celebration somewhere nearby. Participation should always be optional.

Draw a card at random: Once participants are familiar with the deck, invite them to draw a card at random occasionally and try something they might not have chosen. They're always welcome to adapt it or choose another.

Host a supper club: Gather around a shared meal and set aside about 20 minutes for people to share what they tried and learned. The meal remains the main event, while regular reflection sustains the practice and deepens relationships.

Make practice visible: Participants can mark each card they try, or add stickers to an anonymous group chart to show which practices the group returns to most. Treat these as a record of exploration, not a score. There's no expectation to complete the deck or keep pace with anyone else.